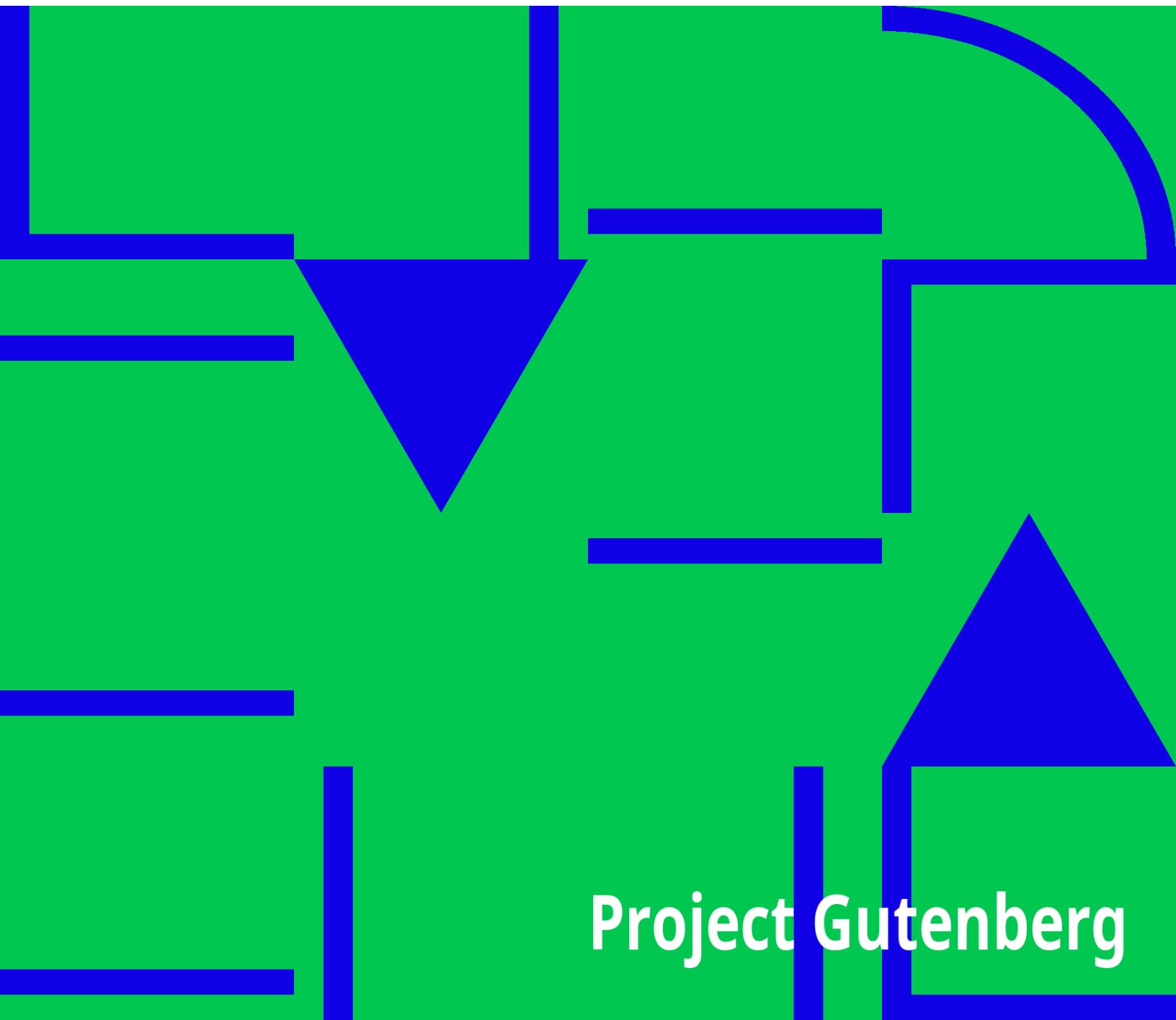


Lyrics of Earth

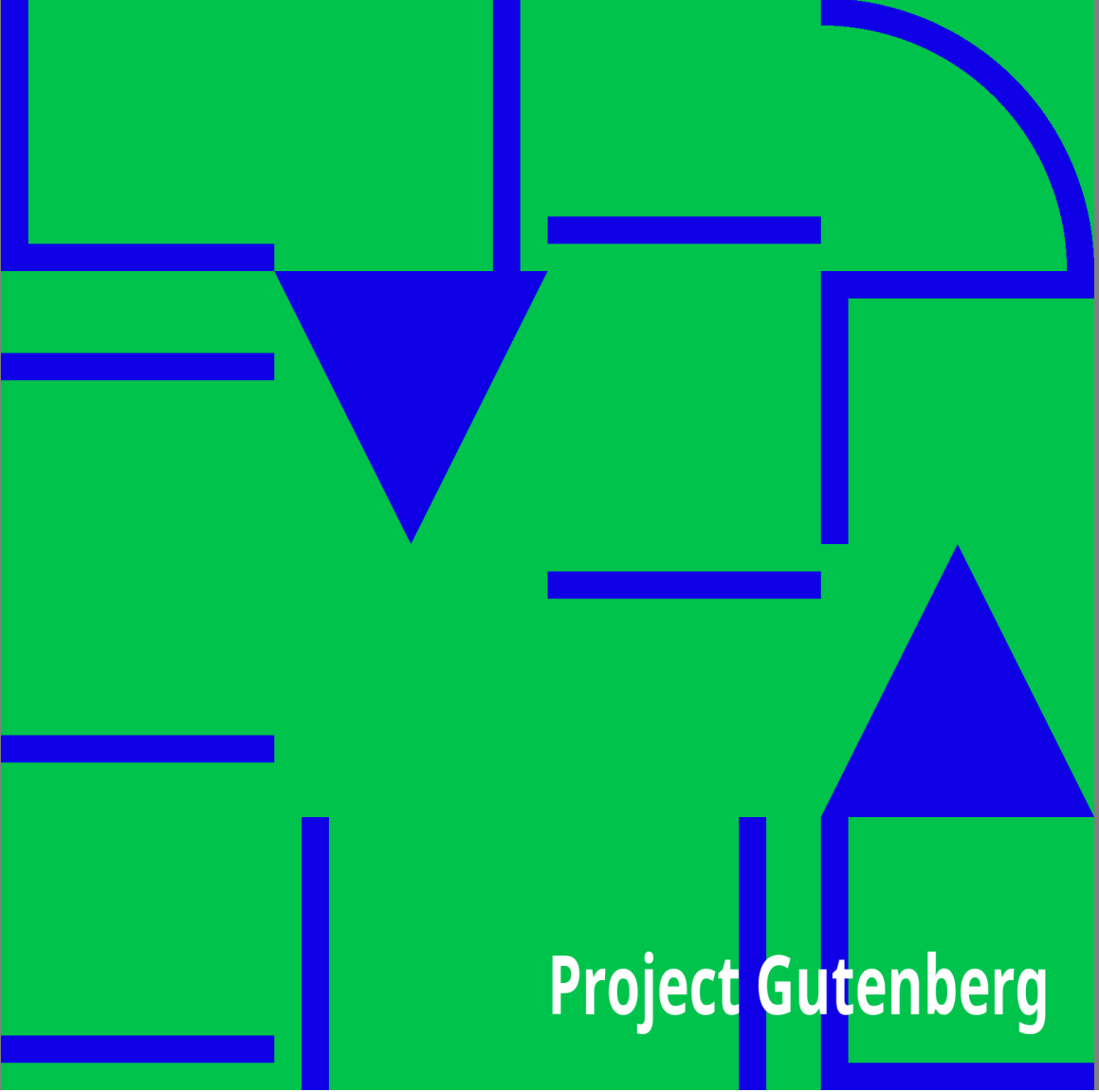
Archibald Lampman

An abstract geometric pattern composed of various blue shapes on a green background. The shapes include horizontal and vertical lines of varying lengths, a large downward-pointing triangle in the center-left, a curved line in the top right corner, and an upward-pointing triangle in the bottom right. The pattern is asymmetrical and modern in style.

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Lyrics of Earth

Archibald Lampman



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Title: Lyrics of Earth

Author: Archibald Lampman

Release date: June 1, 2004 [eBook #12664]

Most recently updated: October 28, 2024

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/12664

Credits: Produced by Andrew Sly.

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EARTH ***

LYRICS OF EARTH

BY

ARCHIBALD LAMPMAN



BOSTON

COPELAND AND DAY

MDCCCXCV

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TO MY MOTHER

Mother, to whose valiant will,
 Battling long ago,
What the heaping years fulfil,
 Light and song, I owe;
Send my little book a-field,
 Fronting praise or blame
With the shining flag and shield
 Of your name.

THE SWEETNESS OF LIFE

It fell on a day I was happy,
And the winds, the concave sky,
The flowers and the beasts in the
meadow
Seemed happy even as I;
And I stretched my hands to the
meadow,
To the bird, the beast, the tree:
"Why are ye all so happy?"
I cried, and they answered me.

What sayest thou, Oh meadow,
That stretches so wide, so far,
That none can say how many
Thy misty marguerites are?
And what say ye, red roses,
That o'er the sun-blanced wall
From your high black-shadowed
trellis
Like flame or blood-drops fall?
"We are born, we are
reared, and we
linger
A various space and
die;
We dream, and are bright
and happy,
But we cannot answer
why."

What sayest thou, Oh shadow,
That from the dreaming hill
All down the broadening valley

Liest so sharp and still?
And thou, Oh murmuring brooklet,
Whereby in the noonday gleam
The loosestrife burns like ruby,
And the branchèd asters dream?

"We are born, we are
reared, and we
linger
A various space and
die;
We dream and are very
happy,
But we cannot answer
why."

And then of myself I questioned,
That like a ghost the while
Stood from me and calmly answered,
With slow and curious smile:
"Thou art born as the flowers, and
wilt linger
Thine own short space and die;
Thou dream'st and art strangely
happy,
But thou canst not answer why."

GOD-SPEED TO THE SNOW

March is slain; the keen winds fly;
Nothing more is thine to do;
April kisses thee good-bye;
Thou must haste and follow too;
Silent friend that guarded well
Withered things to make us glad,
Shyest friend that could not tell
Half the kindly thought he had.
Haste thee, speed thee, O kind snow;
Down the dripping valleys go,
From the fields and gleaming
 meadows,
Where the slaying hours behold thee,
From the forests whose slim
 shadows,
Brown and leafless cannot fold thee,
Through the cedar lands aflame
With gold light that cleaves and
 quivers,
Songs that winter may not tame,
Drone of pines and laugh of rivers.
May thy passing joyous be
To thy father, the great sea,
For the sun is getting stronger;
Earth hath need of thee no longer;
Go, kind snow, God-speed to thee!

APRIL IN THE HILLS

To-day the world is wide and fair
With sunny fields of lucid air,
And waters dancing everywhere;
 The snow is almost gone;
The noon is builded high with light,
And over heaven's liquid height,
In steady fleets serene and white,
 The happy clouds go on.

The channels run, the bare earth
 steams,
And every hollow rings and gleams
With jetting falls and dashing
 streams;
 The rivers burst and fill;
The fields are full of little lakes,
And when the romping wind awakes
The water ruffles blue and shakes,
 And the pines roar on the hill.

The crows go by, a noisy throng;
About the meadows all day long
The shore-lark drops his brittle song;
 And up the leafless tree
The nut-hatch runs, and nods, and
 clings;
The bluebird dips with flashing
 wings,
The robin flutes, the sparrow sings,
 And the swallows float and flee.

I break the spirit's cloudy bands,
A wanderer in enchanted lands,

I feel the sun upon my hands;
 And far from care and strife
The broad earth bids me forth. I rise
With lifted brow and upward eyes.
I bathe my spirit in blue skies,
 And taste the springs of life.

I feel the tumult of new birth;
I waken with the wakening earth;
I match the bluebird in her mirth;
 And wild with wind and sun,
A treasurer of immortal days,
I roam the glorious world with praise,
The hillsides and the woodland ways,
 Till earth and I are one.

FOREST MOODS

There is singing of birds in the deep
 wet woods,
In the heart of the listening solitudes,
Pewees, and thrushes, and sparrows,
 not few,
And all the notes of their throats are
 true.

The thrush from the innermost ash
 takes on
A tender dream of the treasured and
 gone;
But the sparrow singeth with pride
 and cheer
Of the might and light of the present
 and here.

There is shining of flowers in the
 deep wet woods,
In the heart of the sensitive solitudes,
The roseate bell and the lily are there,
And every leaf of their sheaf is fair.

Careless and bold, without dream of
 woe,
The trilliums scatter their flags snow;
But the pale wood-daffodil covers her
 face,
Agloom with the doom of a sorrowful
 race.

THE RETURN OF THE YEAR

Again the warm bare earth, the noon
That hangs upon her healing
scars,
The midnight round, the great red
moon,
The mother with her brood of
stars,

The mist-rack and the wakening rain
Blown soft in many a forest way,
The yellowing elm-trees, and again
The blood-root in its sheath of
gray.

The vesper-sparrow's song, the stress
Of yearning notes that gush and
stream,
The lyric joy, the tenderness,
And once again the dream! the
dream!

A touch of far-off joy and power,
A something it is life to learn,
Comes back to earth, and one short
hour
The glammers of the gods return.

This life's old mood and cult of care
Falls smitten by an older truth,
And the gray world wins back to her
The rapture of her vanished
youth.

Dead thoughts revive, and he that
 heeds
 Shall hear, as by a spirit led,
A song among the golden reeds:
 "The gods are vanished but not
 dead!"

For one short hour; unseen yet near,
 They haunt us, a forgotten
 mood,
A glory upon mead and mere,
 A magic in the leafless wood.

At morning we shall catch the glow
 Of Dian's quiver on the hill,
And somewhere in the glades I know
 That Pan is at his piping still.

FAVORITES OF PAN

Once, long ago, before the gods
 Had left this earth, by stream
 and forest glade,
Where the first plough upturned the
 clinging sods,
Or the lost shepherd strayed,

Often to the tired listener's ear
 There came at noonday or
 beneath the stars
A sound, he knew not whence, so
 sweet and clear,
That all his aches and scars

And every brooded bitterness,
 Fallen asunder from his soul
 took flight,
Like mist or darkness yielding to the
 press
Of an unnamed delight,—

A sudden brightness of the heart,
 A magic fire drawn down from
 Paradise,
That rent the cloud with golden
 gleam apart,—
And far before his eyes

The loveliness and calm of earth
 Lay like a limitless dream
 remote and strange,
The joy, the strife, the triumph and
 the mirth,

And the enchanted change;

And so he followed the sweet sound,
Till faith had traversed her
appointed span,
And murmured as he pressed the
sacred ground:
"It is the note of Pan!"

Now though no more by marsh or
stream
Or dewy forest sounds the secret
reed—
For Pan is gone—Ah yet, the infinite
dream
Still lives for them that heed.

In April, when the turning year
Regains its pensive youth, and a
soft breath
And amorous influence over marsh
and mere
Dissolves the grasp of death,

To them that are in love with life,
Wandering like children with
untroubled eyes,
Far from the noise of cities and the
strife,
Strange flute-like voices rise

At noon and in the quiet of the night
From every watery waste; and in
that hour
The same strange spell, the same
unnamed delight,
Enfolds them in its power.

An old-world joyousness supreme,
The warmth and glow of an
immortal balm,
The mood-touch of the gods, the
endless dream,
The high lethean calm.

They see, wide on the eternal way,
The services of earth, the life of
man;
And, listening to the magic cry they
say:
"It is the note of Pan!"

For, long ago, when the new strains
Of hostile hymns and
conquering faiths grew
keen,
And the old gods from their deserted
fanes,
Fled silent and unseen,

So, too, the goat-foot Pan, not less
Sadly obedient to the mightier
hand,
Cut him new reeds, and in a sore
distress
Passed out from land to land;

And lingering by each haunt he knew,
Of fount or sinuous stream or
grassy marge,
He set the syrinx to his lips, and blew
A note divinely large;

And all around him on the wet
Cool earth the frogs came up,
and with a smile

He took them in his hairy hands, and
set

His mouth to theirs awhile,

And blew into their velvet throats;

And ever from that hour the
frogs repeat

The murmur of Pan's pipes, the notes,

And answers strange and sweet;

And they that hear them are renewed

By knowledge in some god-like
touch conveyed,

Entering again into the eternal mood,

Wherein the world was made.

THE MEADOW

Here when the cloudless April days
begin,
And the quaint crows flock
thicker day by day,
Filling the forests with a pleasant din,
And the soiled snow creeps
secretly away,
Comes the small busy sparrow,
primed with glee,
First preacher in the naked
wilderness,
Piping an end to all the
long distress
From every fence and every leafless
tree.

Now with soft slight and viewless
artifice
Winter's iron work is
wondrously undone;
In all the little hollows cored with ice
The clear brown pools
stand simmering in
the sun,
Frail lucid worlds, upon whose
tremulous floors
All day the wandering
water-bugs at will,
Shy mariners whose oars
are never still,
Voyage and dream about the
heightening shores.

The bluebird, peeping from the
 gnarlèd thorn,
 Prattles upon his frolic
 flute, or flings,
In bounding flight across the golden
 morn,
 An azure gleam from off
 his splendid wings.
Here the slim-pinioned swallows
 sweep and pass
 Down to the far-off river;
 the black crow
 With wise and wary visage
 to and fro
Settles and stalks about the withered
 grass.

Here, when the murmurous May-day
 is half gone,
 The watchful lark before
 my feet takes flight,
And wheeling to some lonelier field
 far on,
 Drops with obstreperous
 cry; and here at
 night,
When the first star precedes the great
 red moon,
 The shore-lark tinkles from
 the darkening field,
 Somewhere, we know not,
 in the dusk
 concealed,
His little creakling and continuous
 tune.

Here, too, the robins, lusty as of old,

Hunt the waste grass for
forage, or prolong
From every quarter of these fields the
bold,
Blithe phrases of their
never-finished song.
The white-throat's distant descant
with slow stress
Note after note upon the
noonday falls,
Filling the leisured air at
intervals
With his own mood of piercing
pensiveness.

How often from this windy upland
perch,
Mine eyes have seen the
forest break in
bloom,
The rose-red maple and the golden
birch,
The dusty yellow of the
elms, the gloom
Of the tall poplar hung with tasseled
black;
Ah, I have watched, till eye
and ear and brain
Grew full of dreams as
they, the moted
plain,
The sun-steeped wood, the marsh-
land at its back,
The valley where the river wheels
and fills,

Yon city glimmering in its
smoky shroud,
And out at the last misty rim the hills
Blue and far off and
mounded like a
cloud,
And here the noisy rutted road that
goes
Down the slope yonder,
flanked on either
side
With the smooth-furrowed
fields flung black
and wide,
Patched with pale water sleeping in
the rows.

So as I watched the crowded leaves
expand,
The bloom break sheath,
the summer's
strength uprear,
In earth's great mother's heart already
planned
The heaped and burgeoned
plenty of the year,
Even as she from out her wintry cell
My spirit also sprang to life
anew,
And day by day as the
spring's bounty
grew,
Its conquering joy possessed me like
a spell.

In reverie by day and midnight dream

I sought these upland fields
and walked apart,
Musing on Nature, till my thought did
seem

To read the very secrets of
her heart;
In mooded moments earnest and
sublime

I stored the themes of many
a future song,
Whose substance should be
Nature's, clear and
strong,
Bound in a casket of majestic rhyme.

Brave bud-like plans that never
reached the fruit,
Like hers our mother's who
with every hour,
Easily replenished from the sleepless
root,

Covers her bosom with
fresh bud and
flower;
Yet I was happy as young lovers be,
Who in the season of their
passion's birth
Deem that they have their
utmost worship's
worth,
If love be near them, just to hear and
see.

IN MAY

Grief was my master yesternight;
 To-morrow I may grieve
 again;
But now along the windy
 plain
 The clouds have taken
 flight.

The sowers in the furrows go;
 The lusty river brimmeth
 on;
The curtains from the hills
 are gone;
 The leaves are out;
 and lo,

The silvery distance of the day,
 The light horizons, and
 between
The glory of the perfect
 green,
 The tumult of the May.

The bobolinks at noonday sing
 More softly than the softest
 flute,
And lightlier than the
 lightest lute
 Their fairy tambours
 ring.

The roads far off are towered with
 dust;

The cherry-blooms are
swept and thinned;
In yonder swaying elms the
wind
Is charging gust on
gust.

But here there is no stir at all;
The ministers of sun and
shadow
Horde all the perfumes of
the meadow
Behind a grassy wall.

An infant rivulet wind-free
Adown the guarded hollow
sets,
Over whose brink the
violets
Are nodding
peacefully.

From pool to pool it prattles by;
The flashing swallows dip
and pass,
Above the tufted marish
grass,
And here at rest am I.

I care not for the old distress,
Nor if to-morrow bid me
moan;
To-day is mine, and I have
known
An hour of
blessedness.

LIFE AND NATURE

I passed through the gates of the city,
The streets were strange and
still,
Through the doors of the open
churches
The organs were moaning shrill.

Through the doors and the great high
windows
I heard the murmur of prayer,
And the sound of their solemn
singing
Streamed out on the sunlit air;

A sound of some great burden
That lay on the world's dark
breast,
Of the old, and the sick, and the
lonely,
And the weary that cried for rest.

I strayed through the midst of the city
Like one distracted or mad.
"Oh, Life! Oh, Life!" I kept saying,
And the very word seemed sad.

I passed through the gates of the city,
And I heard the small birds sing,
I laid me down in the meadows
Afar from the bell-ringing.

In the depth and the bloom of the
meadows

I lay on the earth's quiet breast,
The poplar fanned me with shadows,
And the veery sang me to rest.

Blue, blue was the heaven above me,
And the earth green at my feet;
"Oh, Life! Oh, Life!" I kept saying,
And the very word seemed
sweet.

WITH THE NIGHT

O doubts, dull passions, and base
 fears,
 That harassed and oppressed the
 day,
Ye poor remorsees and vain tears,
 That shook this house of clay:

All heaven to the western bars
 Is glittering with the darker
 dawn;
Here with the earth, the night, the
 stars,
 Ye have no place: begone!

JUNE

Long, long ago, it seems, this summer
morn

That pale-browed April
passed with pensive
tread

Through the frore woods,
and from its frost-
bound bed

Woke the arbutus with her silver
horn;

And now May,
too, is
fled,

The flower-crowned month, the
merry laughing May,
With rosy feet and fingers
dewy wet,

Leaving the woods and all cool
gardens gay
With tulips and the scented
violet.

Gone are the wind-flower and the
adder-tongue

And the sad drooping
bellwort, and no
more

The snowy trilliums crowd
the forest's floor;

The purpling grasses are no longer
young,

And summer's
wide-set
door
O'er the thronged hills and the broad
panting earth
Lest in the torrent of the
later bloom,
Haytime, and harvest, and the after
mirth,
The slow soft rain, the
rushing thunder
plume.

All day in garden alleys moist and
dim,
The humid air is burdened
with the rose;
In moss-deep woods the
creamy orchid
blows;
And now the vesper-sparrows'
pealing hymn
From every
orchard
close
At eve comes flooding rich and
silvery;
The daisies in great
meadows swing and
shine;
And with the wind a sound as of the
sea
Roars in the maples and the
topmost pine.

High in the hills the solitary thrush

Tunes magically his music
of fine dreams,
In briary dells, by boulder-
broken streams;
And wide and far on nebulous fields
aflush

The mellow
morning
gleams.
The orange cone-flowers purple-
bossed are there,
The meadow's bold-eyed
gypsies deep of hue,
And slender hawkweed tall and softly
fair,
And rosy tops of fleabane
veiled with dew.

So with thronged voices and
unhasting flight
The fervid hours with long
return go by;
The far-heard hylas piping
shrill and high
Tell the slow moments of the solemn
night

With unremitting
cry;
Lustrous and large out of the
gathering drouth
The planets gleam; the
baleful Scorpion
Trails his dim fires along the droused
south;
The silent world-incrusted
round moves on.

And all the dim night long the moon's
white beams

Nestle deep down in every
brooding tree,

And sleeping birds, touched
with a silly glee,

Waken at midnight from their blissful
dreams,

And carol
brokenly.

Dim surging motions and uneasy
dreads

Scare the light slumber
from men's busy
eyes,

And parted lovers on their restless
beds

Toss and yearn out, and
cannot sleep for
sighs.

Oft have I striven, sweet month, to
figure thee,

As dreamers of old time
were wont to feign,
In living form of flesh, and
striven in vain;

Yet when some sudden old-world
mystery

Of passion fired
my brain,

Thy shape hath flashed upon me like
no dream,

Wandering with scented
curls that heaped the
breeze,

Or by the hollow of some reeded
stream
Sitting waist-deep in white
anemones;

And even as I glimpsed thee thou
wert gone,
A dream for mortal eyes too
proudly coy,
Yet in thy place for subtle
thought's employ
The golden magic clung, a light that
shone

And filled me
with thy
joy.

Before me like a mist that streamed
and fell

All names and shapes of
antique beauty
passed

In garlanded procession with the
swell

Of flutes between the
beechen stems; and
last,

I saw the Arcadian valley, the loved
wood,

Alpheus stream divine, the
sighing shore,

And through the cool green
glades, awake once
more,

Psyche, the white-limbed goddess,
still pursued,

Fleet-footed as of
yore,
The noonday ringing with her
frighted peals,
Down the bright sward and
through the reeds
she ran,
Urged by the mountain echoes, at her
heels
The hot-blown cheeks and
trampling feet of
Pan.

DISTANCE

To the distance! Ah, the distance!
Blue and broad and dim!
Peace is not in burgh or meadow,
But beyond the rim.

Aye, beyond it, far beyond it;
Follow still my soul,
Till this earth is lost in heaven,
And thou feel'st the whole.

THE BIRD AND THE HOUR

The sun looks over a little hill
And floods the valley with gold

—

A torrent of gold;
And the hither field is green and still;
Beyond it a cloud outrolled,
Is glowing molten and bright;
And soon the hill, and the valley and
all,

With a quiet fall,
Shall be gathered into the night.
And yet a moment more,

Out of the silent
wood,

As if from the closing door
Of another world and another lovelier
mood,

Hear'st thou the hermit pour—

So sweet! so
magical!

—

His golden music, ghostly beautiful.

AFTER RAIN

For three whole days across the sky,
In sullen packs that loomed and
 broke,
With flying fringes dim as smoke,
The columns of the rain went by;
At every hour the wind awoke;
 The darkness passed upon
 the plain;
 The great drops rattled at
 the pane.

Now piped the wind, or far aloof
Fell to a sough remote and dull;
And all night long with rush and lull
The rain kept drumming on the roof:
I heard till ear and sense were full
 The clash or silence of the
 leaves,
 The gurgle in the creaking
 eaves.

But when the fourth day came—at
 noon,
The darkness and the rain were by;
The sunward roofs were steaming
 dry;
And all the world was flecked and
 strewn
With shadows from a fleecy sky.
 The haymakers were forth
 and gone,
 And every rillet laughed
 and shone.

Then, too, on me that loved so well
The world, despairing in her blight,
Uplifted with her least delight,
On me, as on the earth, there fell
New happiness of mirth and might;
 I strode the valleys pied and
 still;
 I climbed upon the breezy
 hill.

I watched the gray hawk wheel and
 drop,
Sole shadow on the shining world;
I saw the mountains clothed and
 curled,
With forest ruffling to the top;
I saw the river's length unfurled,
 Pale silver down the fruited
 plain,
 Grown great and stately
 with the rain.

Through miles of shadow and soft
 heat,
Where field and fallow, fence and
 tree,
Were all one world of greenery,
I heard the robin ringing sweet,
The sparrow piping silverly,
 The thrushes at the forest's
 hem;
 And as I went I sang with
 them.

CLOUD-BREAK

With a turn of his magical rod,
That extended and suddenly shone,
From the round of his glory some god
Looks forth and is gone.

To the summit of heaven the clouds
Are rolling aloft like steam;
There's a break in their infinite
 shrouds,
And below it a gleam.
O'er the drift of the river a whiff
Comes out from the blossoming
 shore;
And the meadows are greening, as if
They never were green before.

The islands are kindled with gold
And russet and emerald dye;
And the interval waters outrolled
Are more blue than the sky.
From my feet to the heart of the hills
The spirits of May intervene,
And a vapor of azure distills
Like a breath on the opaline green.

Only a moment!—and then
The chill and the shadow decline,
On the eyes of rejuvenate men
That were wide and divine.

THE MOON-PATH

The full, clear moon uprose and
 spread
 Her cold, pale splendor o'er the
 sea;
A light-strewn path that seemed to
 lead
 Outward into eternity.
Between the darkness and the gleam
 An old-world spell encompassed
 me:
Methought that in a godlike dream
 I trod upon the sea.

And lo! upon that glimmering road,
 In shining companies unfurled,
The trains of many a primal god,
 The monsters of the elder world;
Strange creatures that, with silver
 wings,
 Scarce touched the ocean's
 thronging floor,
The phantoms of old tales, and things
 Whose shapes are known no
 more.

Giants and demi-gods who once
 Were dwellers of the earth and
 sea,
And they who from Deucalion's
 stones,
 Rose men without an infancy;
Beings on whose majestic lids

Time's solemn secrets seemed to
 dwell,
Tritons and pale-limbed Nereids,
 And forms of heaven and hell.

Some who were heroes long of yore,
 When the great world was hale
 and young;
And some whose marble lips yet pour
 The murmur of an antique
 tongue;
Sad queens, whose names are like
 soft moans,
 Whose griefs were written up in
 gold;
And some who on their silver thrones
 Were goddesses of old.

As if I had been dead indeed,
 And come into some after-land,
I saw them pass me, and take heed,
 And touch me with each mighty
 hand;
And evermore a murmurous stream,
 So beautiful they seemed to me,
Not less than in a godlike dream
 I trod the shining sea.

COMFORT OF THE FIELDS

What would'st thou have for
 easement after grief,
When the rude world hath used
 thee with despite,
And care sits at thine elbow day
 and night,
Filching thy pleasures like a subtle
 thief?
To me, when life besets me in such
 wise,
'Tis sweetest to break forth, to drop
 the chain,
And grasp the freedom of this
 pleasant earth,
To roam in idleness and sober
 mirth,
Through summer airs and summer
 lands, and drain
The comfort of wide fields unto tired
 eyes.

By hills and waters, farms and
 solitudes,
To wander by the day with
 wilful feet;
Through fielded valleys wide
 with yellowing wheat;
Along gray roads that run between
 deep woods,
Murmurous and cool; through
 hallowed slopes of pine,

Where the long daylight dreams,
unpierced, unstirred,
And only the rich-throated
thrush is heard;
By lonely forest brooks that froth and
shine
In bouldered crannies buried in
the hills;
By broken beeches tangled with wild
vine,
And log-strewn rivers
murmurous with mills.

In upland pastures, sown with gold,
and sweet
With the keen perfume of the
ripening grass,
Where wings of birds and filmy
shadows pass,
Spread thick as stars with shining
marguerite;
To haunt old fences overgrown with
brier,
Muffled in vines, and hawthorns,
and wild cherries,
Rank poisonous ivies, red-
bunched elderberries,
And pièd blossoms to the heart's
desire,
Gray mullein towering into
yellow bloom,
Pink-tasseled milkweed,
breathing dense perfume,
And swarthy vervain, tipped with
violet fire.

To hear at eve the bleating of far
flocks,
The mud-hen's whistle from the
marsh at morn;
To skirt with deafened ears and
brain o'erborne
Some foam-filled rapid charging
down its rocks
With iron roar of waters; far away
Across wide-reeded meres,
pensive with noon,
To hear the querulous outcry of
the loon;
To lie among deep rocks, and watch
all day
On liquid heights the snowy
clouds melt by;
Or hear from wood-capped mountain-
brows the jay
Pierce the bright morning with
his jibing cry.

To feast on summer sounds; the jolted
wains,
The thrasher humming from the
farm near by,
The prattling cricket's
intermittent cry,
The locust's rattle from the sultry
lanes;
Or in the shadow of some oaken
spray,
To watch, as through a mist of
light and dreams,
The far-off hay-fields, where the
dusty teams

Drive round and round the lessening
squares of hay,
And hear upon the wind, now
loud, now low,
With drowsy cadence half a summer's
day,
The clatter of the reapers come
and go.

Far violet hills, horizons filmed with
showers,
The murmur of cool streams, the
forest's gloom,
The voices of the breathing
grass, the hum
Of ancient gardens overbanked with
flowers:
Thus, with a smile as golden as the
dawn,
And cool fair fingers radiantly
divine,
The mighty mother brings us in
her hand,
For all tired eyes and foreheads
pinched and wan,
Her restful cup, her beaker of bright
wine:
Drink, and be filled, and ye shall
understand!

AT THE FERRY

On such a day the shrunken stream
 Spends its last water and runs
 dry;

Clouds like far turrets in a dream
 Stand baseless in the burning
 sky.

On such a day at every rod
 The toilers in the hay-field halt,
With dripping brows, and the parched
 sod
 Yields to the crushing foot like
 salt.

But here a little wind astir,
 Seen waterward in jetting lines,
From yonder hillside topped with fir
 Comes pungent with the breath
 of pines;
And here when all the noon hangs
 still,
 White-hot upon the city tiles,
A perfume and a wintry chill
 Breathe from the yellow lumber-
 piles.

And all day long there falls a blur
 Of noises upon listless ears,
The rumble of the trams, the stir
 Of barges at the clacking piers;
The champ of wheels, the crash of
 steam,
 And ever, without change or
 stay,

The drone, as through a troubled
dream,
Of waters falling far away.

A tug-boat up the farther shore
Half pants, half whistles, in her
draught;
The cadence of a creaking oar
Falls drowsily; a corded raft
Creeps slowly in the noonday gleam,
And wheresoe'er a shadow
sleeps
The men lie by, or half a-dream,
Stand leaning at the idle sweeps.

And all day long in the quiet bay
The eddying amber depths
retard,
And hold, as in a ring, at play,
The heavy saw-logs notched and
scarred;
And yonder between cape and shoal,
Where the long currents swing
and shift,
An aged punt-man with his pole
Is searching in the parted drift.

At moments from the distant glare
The murmur of a railway steals
Round yonder jutting point the air
Is beaten with the puff of
wheels;
And here at hand an open mill,
Strong clamor at perpetual drive,
With changing chant, now hoarse,
now shrill,

Keeps dinning like a mighty
hive.

A furnace over field and mead,
The rounding noon hangs hard
and white;
Into the gathering heats recede
The hollows of the Chelsea
height;
But under all to one quiet tune,
A spirit in cool depths
withdrawn,
With logs, and dust, and wrack
bestrewn,
The stately river journeys on.

I watch the swinging currents go
Far down to where, enclosed and
piled,
The logs crowd, and the Gatineau
Comes rushing from the
northern wild.
I see the long low point, where close
The shore-lines, and the waters
end,
I watch the barges pass in rows
That vanish at the tapering bend.

I see as at the noon's pale core—
A shadow that lifts clear and
floats—
The cabin'd village round the shore,
The landing and the fringe of
boats;
Faint films of smoke that curl and
wreathe,
And upward with the like desire

The vast gray church that seems to
 breathe
In heaven with its dreaming
 spire.

And there the last blue boundaries
 rise,
 That guard within their compass
 furl
This plot of earth: beyond them lies
 The mystery of the echoing
 world;
And still my thought goes on, and
 yields
 New vision and new joy to me,
Far peopled hills, and ancient fields,
 And cities by the crested sea.

I see no more the barges pass,
 Nor mark the ripple round the
 pier,
And all the uproar, mass on mass,
 Falls dead upon a vacant ear.
Beyond the tumult of the mills,
 And all the city's sound and
 strife,
Beyond the waste, beyond the hills,
 I look far out and dream of life.

SEPTEMBER

Now hath the summer reached her
 golden close,
And, lost amid her corn-fields,
 bright of soul,
Scarcely perceives from her divine
 repose
How near, how swift, the
 inevitable goal:
Still, still, she smiles, though from
 her careless feet
The bounty and the fruitful
 strength are gone,
And through the soft long
 wondering days goes on
The silent sere decadence sad and
 sweet.

The kingbird and the pensive thrush
 are fled,
Children of light, too fearful of
 the gloom;
The sun falls low, the secret word is
 said,
The mouldering woods grow
 silent as the tomb;
Even the fields have lost their
 sovereign grace,
The cone-flower and the
 marguerite; and no more,
Across the river's shadow-
 haunted floor,

The paths of skimming swallows
interlace.

Already in the outland wilderness
The forests echo with unwonted
dins;
In clamorous gangs the gathering
woodmen press
Northward, and the stern
winter's toil begins.
Around the long low shanties, whose
rough lines
Break the sealed dreams of
many an unnamed lake,
Already in the frost-clear morns
awake
The crash and thunder of the falling
pines.

Where the tilled earth, with all its
fields set free,
Naked and yellow from the
harvest lies,
By many a loft and busy granary,
The hum and tumult of the
thrashers rise;
There the tanned farmers labor
without slack,
Till twilight deepens round the
spouting mill,
Feeding the loosened sheaves, or
with fierce will,
Pitching waist-deep upon the dusty
stack.

Still a brief while, ere the old year
quite pass,

Our wandering steps and wistful
 eyes shall greet
The leaf, the water, the beloved grass;
 Still from these haunts and this
 accustomed seat
I see the wood-wrapt city, swept with
 light,
 The blue long-shadowed
 distance, and, between,
 The dotted farm-lands with their
 parcelled green,
The dark pine forest and the watchful
 height.

I see the broad rough meadow
 stretched away
 Into the crystal sunshine, wastes
 of sod,
Acres of withered vervain, purple-
 gray,
 Branches of aster, groves of
 goldenrod;
And yonder, toward the sunlit
 summit, strewn
 With shadowy boulders,
 crowned and swathed
 with weed,
 Stand ranks of silken thistles,
 blown to seed,
Long silver fleeces shining like the
 noon.

In far-off russet corn-fields, where the
 dry
 Gray shocks stand peaked and
 withering, half concealed

In the rough earth, the orange
pumpkins lie,
Full-ribbed; and in the windless
pasture-field
The sleek red horses o'er the sun-
warmed ground
Stand pensively about in
companies,
While all around them from the
motionless trees
The long clean shadows sleep without
a sound.

Under cool elm-trees floats the
distant stream,
Moveless as air; and o'er the vast
warm earth
The fathomless daylight seems to
stand and dream,
A liquid cool elixir—all its girth
Bound with faint haze, a frail
transparency,
Whose lucid purple barely veils
and fills
The utmost valleys and the thin
last hills,
Nor mars one whit their perfect
clarity.

Thus without grief the golden days go
by,
So soft we scarcely notice how
they wend,
And like a smile half happy, or a sigh,
The summer passes to her quiet
end;

And soon, too soon, around the
 cumbered eaves
Sly frosts shall take the creepers
 by surprise,
And through the wind-touched
 reddening woods shall
 rise
October with the rain of ruined
 leaves.

A RE-ASSURANCE

With what doubting eyes, oh sparrow,
 Thou regardest me,
Underneath yon spray of yarrow,
 Dipping cautiously.

Fear me not, oh little sparrow,
 Bathe and never fear,
For to me both pool and yarrow
 And thyself are dear.

THE POET'S POSSESSION

Think not, oh master of the well-tilled
field,
This earth is only thine; for after thee,
When all is sown and gathered and
put by,
Comes the grave poet with creative
eye,
And from these silent acres and clean
plots,
Bids with his wand the fancied after-
yield,
A second tilth and second harvest, be,
The crop of images and curious
thoughts.

AN AUTUMN LANDSCAPE

No wind there is that either pipes or
moans;
The fields are cold and still; the
sky
Is covered with a blue-gray
sheet
Of motionless cloud; and at
my feet
The river, curling softly by,
Whispers and dimples round its quiet
gray stones.

Along the chill green slope that dips
and heaves
The road runs rough and silent,
lined
With plum-trees, misty and
blue-gray,
And poplars pallid as the
day,
In masses spectral, undefined,
Pale greenish stems half hid in dry
gray leaves.

And on beside the river's sober edge
A long fresh field lies black.
Beyond,
Low thickets gray and
reddish stand,
Stroked white with birch;
and near at hand,
Over a little steel-smooth pond,

Hang multitudes of thin and
withering sedge.

Across a waste and solitary rise
A ploughman urges his dull
team,
A stooped gray figure with
prone brow
That plunges bending to the
plough
With strong, uneven steps. The
stream
Rings and re-echoes with his furious
cries.

Sometimes the lowing of a cow, long-
drawn,
Comes from far off; and crows
in strings
Pass on the upper silences.
A flock of small gray
goldfinches,
Flown down with silvery
twitterings,
Rustle among the birch-cones and are
gone.

This day the season seems like one
that heeds,
With fixèd ear and lifted hand,
All moods that yet are
known on earth,
All motions that have
faintest birth,
If haply she may understand
The utmost inward sense of all her
deeds.

IN NOVEMBER

With loitering step and quiet eye,
Beneath the low November sky,
I wandered in the woods, and found
A clearing, where the broken ground
Was scattered with black stumps and
briers,

And the old wreck of forest fires.
It was a bleak and sandy spot,
And, all about, the vacant plot
Was peopled and inhabited
By scores of mulleins long since
dead.

A silent and forsaken brood
In that mute opening of the wood,
So shrivelled and so thin they were,
So gray, so haggard, and austere,
Not plants at all they seemed to me,
But rather some spare company
Of hermit folk, who long ago,
Wandering in bodies to and fro,
Had chanced upon this lonely way,
And rested thus, till death one day
Surprised them at their compline
prayer,
And left them standing lifeless there.

There was no sound about the wood
Save the wind's secret stir. I stood
Among the mullein-stalks as still
As if myself had grown to be
One of their sombre company,
A body without wish or will.

And as I stood, quite suddenly,
Down from a furrow in the sky
The sun shone out a little space
Across that silent sober place,
Over the sand heaps and brown sod,
The mulleins and dead goldenrod,
And passed beyond the thickets gray,
And lit the fallen leaves that lay,
Level and deep within the wood,
A rustling yellow multitude.

And all around me the thin light,
So sere, so melancholy bright,
Fell like the half-reflected gleam
Or shadow of some former dream;
A moment's golden revery
Poured out on every plant and tree
A semblance of weird joy, or less,
A sort of spectral happiness;
And I, too, standing idly there,
With muffled hands in the chill air,
Felt the warm glow about my feet,
And shuddering betwixt cold and
 heat,
Drew my thoughts closer, like a
 cloak,
While something in my blood awoke,
A nameless and unnatural cheer,
A pleasure secret and austere.

BY AN AUTUMN STREAM

Now overhead,
Where the rivulet loiters and stops,
The bittersweet hangs from the tops
Of the alders and cherries
Its bunches of beautiful berries,
Orange and red.

And the snowbirds flee,
Tossing up on the far brown field,
Now flashing and now concealed,
Like fringes of spray
That vanish and gleam on the gray
Field of the sea.

Flickering light,
Come the last of the leaves down
 borne,
And patches of pale white corn
In the wind complain,
Like the slow rustle of rain
Noticed by night.

Withered and thinned,
The sentinel mullein looms,
With the pale gray shadowy plumes
Of the goldenrod;
And the milkweed opens its pod,
Tempting the wind.

Aloft on the hill,
A cloudrift opens and shines
Through a break in its gorget of
 pines,

And it dreams at my feet
In a sad, silvery sheet,
Utterly still.

All things that be
Seem plunged into silence,
 distraught,
By some stern, some necessitous
 thought:
It wraps and enthralls
Marsh, meadow, and forest; and falls
Also on me.

SNOWBIRDS

Along the narrow sandy height
I watch them swiftly come and
go,
Or round the leafless wood,
Like flurries of wind-driven
snow,
Revolving in perpetual flight,
A changing multitude.

Nearer and nearer still they sway,
And, scattering in a circled
sweep,
Rush down without a
sound;
And now I see them peer and
peep,
Across yon level bleak and gray,
Searching the frozen
ground,—

Until a little wind upheaves,
And makes a sudden rustling
there,
And then they drop their
play,
Flash up into the sunless air,
And like a flight of silver leaves
Swirl round and sweep
away.

SNOW

White are the far-off plains, and white
 The fading forests grow;
The wind dies out along the height,
 And denser still the snow,
A gathering weight on roof and tree,
 Falls down scarce audibly.

The road before me smooths and fills
 Apace, and all about
The fences dwindle, and the hills
 Are blotted slowly out;
The naked trees loom spectrally
 Into the dim white sky.

The meadows and far-sheeted streams
 Lie still without a sound;
Like some soft minister of dreams
 The snow-fall hoods me
 round;
In wood and water, earth and air,
 A silence everywhere.

Save when at lonely intervals
 Some farmer's sleigh, urged
 on,
With rustling runners and sharp bells,
 Swings by me and is gone;
Or from the empty waste I hear
 A sound remote and clear;

The barking of a dog, or call
 To cattle, sharply pealed,

Borne echoing from some wayside
stall

Or barnyard far a-field;
Then all is silent, and the snow
Falls, settling soft and slow.

The evening deepens, and the gray
Folds closer earth and sky;
The world seems shrouded far away;
Its noises sleep, and I,
As secret as yon buried stream,
Plod dumbly on, and
dream.

SUNSET

From this windy bridge at rest,
In some former curious hour,
We have watched the city's hue,
All along the orange west,
Cupola and pointed tower,
Darken into solid blue.

Tho' the biting north wind breaks
Full across this drifted hold,
Let us stand with icèd cheeks
Watching westward as of old;

Past the violet mountain-head
To the farthest fringe of pine,
Where far off the purple-red
Narrows to a dusky line,
And the last pale splendors die
Slowly from the olive sky;

Till the thin clouds wear away
Into threads of purple-gray,
And the sudden stars between
Brighten in the pallid green;

Till above the spacious east,
Slow returnèd one by one,
Like pale prisoners released
From the dungeons of the sun,
Capella and her train appear
In the glittering Charioteer;

Till the rounded moon shall grow
Great above the eastern snow,

Shining into burnished gold;
And the silver earth outrolled,
In the misty yellow light,
Shall take on the width of night.

WINTER-STORE

Subtly conscious, all awake,
Let us clear our eyes, and break
Through the cloudy chrysalis,
See the wonder as it is.
Down a narrow alley, blind,
Touch and vision, heart and mind;
Turned sharply inward, still we plod,
Till the calmly smiling god
Leaves us, and our spirits grow
More thin, more acrid, as we go.
Creeping by the sullen wall,
We forego the power to see,
The threads that bind us to the All,
God or the Immensity;
Whereof on the eternal road
Man is but a passing mode.

Too blind we are, too little see
Of the magic pageantry,
Every minute, every hour,
From the cloudflake to the flower,
Forever old, forever strange,
Issuing in perpetual change
From the rainbow gates of Time.

But he who through this common air
Surely knows the great and fair,
What is lovely, what sublime,
Becomes in an increasing span,
One with earth and one with man,
One, despite these mortal scars,
With the planets and the stars;
And Nature from her holy place,

Bending with unveiled face,
Fills him in her divine employ
With her own majestic joy.

Up the fielded slopes at morn,
Where light wefts of shadow pass,
Films upon the bending corn,
I shall sweep the purple grass.
Sun-crowned heights and mossy
 woods,
And the outer solitudes,
Mountain-valleys, dim with pine,
Shall be home and haunt of mine.
I shall search in crannied hollows,
Where the sunlight scarcely follows,
And the secret forest brook
Murmurs, and from nook to nook
Forever downward curls and cools,
Frothing in the bouldered pools.

Many a noon shall find me laid
In the pungent balsam shade,
Where sharp breezes spring and
 shiver
On some deep rough-coasted river,
And the plangent waters come,
Amber-hued and streaked with foam;
Where beneath the sunburnt hills
All day long the crowded mills
With remorseless champ and scream
Overlord the sluicing stream,
And the rapids' iron roar
Hammers at the forest's core;
Where corded rafts creep slowly on,
Glittering in the noonday sun,
And the tawny river-dogs,
Shepherding the branded logs,

Bind and heave with cadenced cry;
Where the blackened tugs go by,
Panting hard and straining slow,
Laboring at the weighty tow,
Flat-nosed barges all in trim,
Creeping in long cumbrous line,
Loaded to the water's brim
With the clean, cool-scented pine.

Perhaps in some low meadow-land,
Stretching wide on either hand,
I shall see the belted bees
Rocking with the tricky breeze
In the spirèd meadow-sweet,
Or with eager trampling feet
Burrowing in the boneset blooms,
Treading out the dry perfumes.
Where sun-hot hay-fields newly

mown

Climb the hillside ruddy brown,
I shall see the haymakers,
While the noonday scarcely stirs,
Brown of neck and booted gray,
Tossing up the rustling hay,
While the hay-racks bend and rock,
As they take each scented cock,
Jolting over dip and rise;
And the wavering butterflies
O'er the spaces brown and bare
Light and wander here and there.

I shall stray by many a stream,
Where the half-shut lilies gleam.
Napping out the sultry days
In the quiet secluded bays;
Where the tasseled rushes tower,
O'er the purple pickerel-flower.

And the floating dragon-fly—
Azure glint and crystal gleam—
Watches o'er the burnished stream
With his eye of ebony;
Where the bull-frog lolls at rest
On his float of lily-leaves,
That the swaying water weaves,
And distends his yellow breast,
Lowing out from shore to shore
With a hollow vibrant roar;
Where the softest wind that blows
As it lightly comes and goes,
O'er the jungled river meads,
Stirs a whisper in the reeds,
And wakes the crowded bull-rushes
From their stately reveries,
Flashing through their long-leaved
 hordes
Like a brandishing of swords;
There, too, the frost-like arrow-
 flowers
Tremble to the golden core,
Children of enchanted hours,
Whom the rustling river bore
In the night's bewildered noon,
Woven of water and the moon.

I shall hear the grasshoppers
From the parched grass rehearse,
And with drowsy note prolong
Evermore the same thin song.
I shall hear the crickets tell
Stories by the humming well,
And mark the locust, with quaint
 eyes,
Caper in his cloak of gray
Like a jester in disguise

Rattling by the dusty way.

I shall dream by upland fences,
Where the season's wealth condenses
Over many a weedy wreck,
Wild, uncared-for, desert places,
That sovereign Beauty loves to deck
With her softest, dearest graces.
There the long year dreams in quiet,
And the summer's strength runs riot.
Shall I not remember these,
Deep in winter reveries?
Berried brier and thistle-bloom,
And milkweed with its dense
 perfume;
Slender vervain towering up
In a many-branchèd cup,
Like a candlestick, each spire
Kindled with a violet fire;
Matted creepers and wild cherries,
Purple-bunchèd elderberries,
And on scanty plots of sod
Groves of branchy goldenrod.

What though autumn mornings now,
Winterward with glittering brow,
Stiffen in the silver grass;
And what though robins flock and
 pass,
With subdued and sober call,
To the old year's funeral;
Though October's crimson leaves
Rustle at the gusty door,
And the tempest round the eaves
Alternate with pipe and roar;
I sit, as erst, unharmed, secure,
Conscious that my store is sure,

Whatsoever the fenced fields,
Or the untilled forest yields
Of unhurt remembrances,
Or thoughts, far-glimpsed, half-
followed, these
I have reaped and laid away,
A treasure of unwinnowed grain,
To the garner packed and gray
Gathered without toil or strain.

And when the darker days shall
come,
And the fields are white and dumb;
When our fires are half in vain,
And the crystal starlight weaves
Mockeries of summer leaves,
Pictured on the icy pane;
When the high aurora gleams
Far above the Arctic streams
Like a line of shifting spears,
And the broad pine-circled meres,
Glimmering in that spectral light,
Thunder through the northern night;
Then within the bolted door
I shall con my summer store;
Though the fences scarcely show
Black above the drifted snow,
Though the icy sweeping wind
Whistle in the empty tree,
Safe within the sheltered mind,
I shall feed on memory.

Yet across the windy night
Comes upon its wings a cry;
Fashioned forms and modes take
flight,
And a vision sad and high

Of the laboring world down there,
Where the lights burn red and warm,
Pricks my soul with sudden stare,
Glowing through the veils of storm.
In the city yonder sleep
Those who smile and those who
 weep,
Those whose lips are set with care,
Those whose brows are smooth and
 fair;
Mourners whom the dawning light
Shall grapple with an old distress;
Lovers folded at midnight
In their bridal happiness;
Pale watchers by belovèd beds,
Fallen a-drowse with nodding heads,
Whom sleep captured by surprise,
With the circles round their eyes;
Maidens with quiet-taken breath,
Dreaming of enchanted bowers;
Old men with the mask of death;
Little children soft as flowers;
Those who wake wild-eyed and start
In some madness of the heart;
Those whose lips and brows of stone
Evil thoughts have graven upon,
Shade by shade and line by line,
Refashioning what was once divine.

All these sleep, and through the night,
Comes a passion and a cry,
With a blind sorrow and a might,
I know not whence, I know not why,
A something I cannot control,
A nameless hunger of the soul.
It holds me fast. In vain, in vain,
I remember how of old

I saw the ruddy race of men,
Through the glittering world
 outrolled,
A gay-smiling multitude,
All immortal, all divine,
Treading in a wreathèd line
By a pathway through a wood.

THE SUN CUP

The earth is the cup of the sun,
That he filleth at morning with wine,
With the warm, strong wine of his
 might
From the vintage of gold and of light,
Fills it, and makes it divine.

And at night when his journey is
 done,
At the gate of his radiant hall,
He setteth his lips to the brim,
With a long last look of his eye,
And lifts it and draineth it dry,
Drains till he leaveth it all
Empty and hollow and dim.

And then, as he passes to sleep,
Still full of the feats that he did,
Long ago in Olympian wars,
He closes it down with the sweep
Of its slow-turning luminous lid,
Its cover of darkness and stars,
Wrought once by Hephæstus of old
With violet and vastness and gold.

The first edition of this book consists
of five hundred copies, printed by the
Boston Engraving and McIndoe
Printing Company, Boston, during

March, 1896, with fifty additional
copies on Arnold paper.

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